Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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Jacob

Jacob was the younger twin son of Isaac and Rebekah. He struggled with his twin brother Esau in the womb and was born holding Esau's heel (Genesis 25:21–26). God told Rebekah that the boys symbolized two nations and that the older son would serve the younger (Genesis 25:23).

Isaac favored Esau, who loved the outdoors, while Rebekah preferred Jacob, who enjoyed staying at home. One day, Esau came back very hungry from hunting, and Jacob traded him some red stew for his inheritance rights (Genesis 25:27–34; see Hebrews 12:16). Later, Isaac asked Esau to prepare wild game for him to eat so he could bless him (Genesis 27:1–4; compare 25:28). However, Rebekah sent Jacob to trick Isaac into giving him the blessing instead, and her plan worked (Genesis 27:5–29). Jacob's deception was soon discovered (Genesis 27:30–35). But legally, valid blessings were unchangeable promises (27:33). So Isaac gave Esau a lesser blessing (Genesis 27:36–40). Esau planned to kill Jacob (27:41). Rebekah persuaded Isaac to send Jacob to her brother Laban so Jacob could marry within the family (Genesis 27:42–46).

Isaac gave the covenant promises to Jacob and sent him to Haran (Genesis 28:1–5). On the way, God appeared to Jacob in a dream and confirmed the promises of land and descendants given to Abraham and Isaac (Genesis 28:10–15). Jacob worshiped the Lord and named the place Bethel, meaning "house of God."

In Haran, Jacob worked for his uncle Laban (Genesis 29–31). Jacob loved Laban's daughter Rachel and worked seven years to marry her. However, Laban tricked him by giving him his older daughter Leah on the wedding night. Jacob then worked another seven years for Rachel and six more years to build his own flocks (Genesis 30:25–43; see also 31:38–42). Despite many challenges, he had thirteen children and became very wealthy.

After twenty years, God told Jacob to return to Canaan (Genesis 31:3). Jacob feared Laban and his sons (Genesis 31:1–2). So, he organized his caravan and left while Laban was away (31:4–21). Laban chased after him, but God stopped him from harming Jacob (Genesis 31:22–24, 29). Instead, Laban scolded Jacob for leaving secretly and accused him of stealing his idols (Genesis 31:25–30). Jacob allowed Laban to search his tents, but the idols were not found (Genesis 31:33–35). Jacob then became angry (Genesis 31:36–42). Although their conflict was unresolved, the two men made a peace agreement (Genesis 31:43–54). The location became a lasting boundary between Israel and Aram.

Jacob now faced Esau and God. When Esau came with four hundred men, Jacob asked for God's protection and sent gifts to make peace with his brother, whom he had not seen for many years (Genesis 32:3–21). That night, in an event symbolizing his life, Jacob wrestled with a man who dislocated his hip and gave him the blessing he wanted (Genesis 32:22–32). God also changed his name to Israel, meaning "God fights."

In the morning, Jacob met Esau, and they reconciled (Genesis 33:1–11). Esau was kind and forgiving, and Jacob shared some of his blessings. Esau then returned to Seir, while Jacob continued to Canaan. In Shechem, Jacob bought land and built an altar (Genesis 33:18–20). He then moved to Bethel and removed all foreign idols from his household (Genesis 35:1–8). God reaffirmed Jacob's new name, Israel, and renewed his promises of land and descendants (Genesis 35:9–15).

Jacob favored Rachel and her son Joseph (Genesis 37:1–3). Joseph's brothers grew jealous and hated him. Joseph's dreams made them angrier (Genesis 37:4–11), so they sold him as a slave (Genesis 37:12–28). For over twenty years, Jacob thought Joseph was dead. Jacob only learned Joseph was alive after sending Benjamin to Egypt with Judah. Joseph then helped his family during the famine (Genesis 43:1–14; 45:24–28). Jacob felt renewed and moved to Egypt. He joyfully reunited with Joseph in Goshen (Genesis 46:28–30) and thrived for seventeen more years.

When Jacob was near death at age 147, he planned for his family's future. He made Joseph promise to bury him in Canaan (Genesis 47:29–31; 49:29–32). He gave Joseph's sons his main blessing and placed Ephraim, the younger son, first (Genesis 48:1–20). He assured the family they would return to Canaan (Genesis 48:21–22). Then he blessed each of his sons and predicted the future of their descendants (Genesis 49:1–28). He died and was buried in the cave of Machpelah, accompanied by his sons and a large Egyptian procession (Genesis 49:33–50:13). His death marked the end of the patriarchal age and the start of Israel's growth as a nation in Egypt until they returned to live in the promised land (see Exodus—Joshua).

The name "Jacob" became another name for the nation of Israel (see Numbers 23:7, 21; 24:5; Hosea 12:2). God called the nation to serve him as their ancestors did (Hosea 12:3–14). He promised Israel the same love he showed Jacob (Malachi 1:2). He also promised that a

powerful leader would come from Jacob's descendants (Genesis 49:8–12; Numbers 24:17–19).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 25:19–34; 27:1–35:29; 37:1–35; 42:1–4, 29–38; 43:1–13; 45:25–50:14; Exodus 1:1–5; Numbers 23:7–10, 20–23; 24:5–9, 17–19; Deuteronomy 26:5; Joshua 24:4, 32; Hosea 12:2–14; Malachi 1:2; John 4:5–6, 12; Acts 7:8–16; Romans 9:10–13; Hebrews 11:8–9, 20–21

James, Brother of Jesus

James was one of the brothers of Jesus (Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; Galatians 1:19; compare Jude 1:1). He became the leader of the church in Jerusalem soon after Jesus rose from the dead. According to tradition, this James is the author of the New Testament book of James.

The brothers of Jesus were initially doubtful of his claims (John 7:2–5). But they later became believers (Acts 1:14). James's personal encounter with the risen Jesus might have convinced him (1 Corinthians 15:7). Two of the brothers of Jesus, James and Jude, had important roles in the early Christian community.

James quickly became the leader of the church in Jerusalem. At the council in Jerusalem, James helped Jewish church leaders accept Gentile (non-Jewish) believers without requiring circumcision. This decision was essential for Paul and the early mission to Gentiles (Acts 15:13–21). Paul visited James in Jerusalem after his third missionary trip, just as he had done earlier after his conversion (Acts 21:18; Galatians 1:19).

Like most Jewish Christians, James followed the law of Moses. He stressed the importance of observing certain key laws when among Jews (Acts 15:20–21; 21:18–25). James recognized Paul's mission and focus on salvation through faith alone (Galatians 2:6–9), but many Jewish Christians did not agree. These Jewish believers, whom Paul associated with James once (see Galatians 2:12), insisted that Gentiles who became Christians must be circumcised and follow the law of Moses to join the Christian community.

James's Jewish background is evident in his letter, which offers wise, practical advice for living. Much of it aligns with traditional Jewish Scripture wisdom. One paragraph of his letter (James 5:1–6) resembles the work of Old Testament prophets (for example, compare Amos 5:21–24; 6:1–7).

James, known as "the Just" by people of his time, was killed for his faith by Jewish priests in Jerusalem (Josephus, Antiquities 20.9; Eusebius, Church History 2.23.4–18).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; Acts 12:17; Acts 15:13–21; Acts 21:18–25; 1 Corinthians 15:7; Galatians 2:9, Galatians 2:12; James 1:1–5:20; Jude 1:1

James, Son of Zebedee

James, son of Zebedee and brother of John, was one of the twelve apostles. He was among the first to die as a follower of Jesus. His mother might have been the sister of Mary, the mother of Jesus. This would mean he was the cousin of Jesus (see Matthew 27:56; Mark 15:40; 16:1; John 19:25). His name usually appears before John's, which might mean James was older. This James was not James, son of Alphaeus (see Luke 6:15) or James, brother of Jesus.

James and John were fishermen like their father (Matthew 4:21; Mark 1:19). They fished with Peter and Andrew, another pair of brothers who became disciples (Luke 5:10). They were among the first people Jesus called to be his disciples. They left everything, including their father, to follow him (Matthew 4:22; Mark 1:20; Luke 5:11). Jesus called them "Sons of Thunder" (Mark 3:17). This might mean they had strong personalities (see Luke 9:54), though the exact meaning is unclear.

James and his brother John were very close to Jesus. Along with Peter, they formed a trusted group of disciples who joined Jesus on special occasions. They were with him when he healed Jairus's daughter (Mark 5:37; Luke 8:51), talked with Elijah and Moses on a mountain (Matthew 17:1–3; Mark 9:2–4; Luke 9:28–30), and prayed in the garden (Matthew 26:37; Mark 14:33). At one time, the two brothers upset the other disciples by asking for special positions in the coming kingdom of God (Matthew 20:20–28; Mark 10:35–45; compare Luke 22:24–27).

Herod Agrippa had James killed soon after the death of Jesus, which pleased the Jewish leaders (Acts 12:1–3). Herod might have done this because James was an important leader among the disciples. This event fulfilled the prediction Jesus spoke that James would share in his suffering (Matt 20:23; Mark 10:38–39).

James was an ordinary worker whom Jesus called to be his disciple. He left his job, family, and home to follow Jesus with simple trust. Eventually, he died for Jesus, making him a model of committed discipleship.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 4:21–22; 10:2; 17:1; 20:20–24; 26:37–46; Mark 1:19–20, 29; 3:17; 5:37; 9:2; 10:35–41; 13:3–4; 14:33–42; Luke 5:10; 6:14; 8:51; 9:28, 54–55; John 21:2; Acts 1:13; 12:2

Jehoshaphat

Jehoshaphat became the fourth king of Judah after his father Asa, who ruled from 872 to 848 BC. Like Hezekiah and Josiah, Jehoshaphat trusted the Lord throughout his life. He worked to remove most pagan worship from Israel (2 Chronicles 17:6).

Jehoshaphat continued his father Asa's religious reforms but changed his foreign policy. He stopped Judah's war with Israel over their borders (see 1 Kings 22:2). He allied with Ahab. To strengthen this alliance, he arranged for his son Jehoram to marry Ahab's daughter Athaliah (2 Chronicles 18:1–2; 2 Kings 8:18). He also supported the north in wars against the Arameans and Moabites (2 Chronicles 18:3–34; 1 Kings 22; 2 Kings 3:4–27). The prophet Jehu criticized Jehoshaphat for his unwise alliance with Israel (2 Chronicles 19:1–3). This led to his son Jehoram being influenced by Ahab and Jezebel. Jehoram and his son Ahaziah turned Judah toward idol worship.

During his reign, Jehoshaphat kept the worship of the Lord pure. He closed the temples of prostitution (1 Kings 22:46) and sent teachers of God's law throughout the land (2 Chronicles 17:7–9). He also set up a system of judges and told them to act as the Lord's representatives so that justice would prevail (2 Chronicles 19:4–7). He appointed Levites, priests, and family leaders to handle religious cases and resolve disputes among citizens (2 Chronicles 19:8–10).

Before going to battle, Jehoshaphat insisted on hearing from a true prophet of the Lord. In one of the most powerful descriptions of war in the Old Testament, Jehoshaphat spoke to the army before entering battle. As a result, God caused the armies from Ammon, Moab, and their allies to turn against each other (2 Chronicles 20).

Jehoshaphat died at around sixty years old and was buried in Jerusalem. His son Jehoram became the next king of Judah (2 Chronicles 21:1).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 15:24; 22:1–50; 2 Kings 3:1–27; 2 Chronicles 17:1–21:1

Jeremiah

Jeremiah was a prophet in Jerusalem before its destruction in 586 BC. People sometimes call him the "weeping prophet" because he shared his struggles and sorrows while delivering God's messages.

Jeremiah was born in Anathoth, near Jerusalem, during Manasseh's reign. His father was Hilkiah from the tribe of Benjamin. Jeremiah became a prophet in the thirteenth year of Josiah's reign (627 BC). At first, Jeremiah hesitated to accept his role (Jeremiah 1:6), but God promised to guide and protect him and to provide the words he needed, even when facing opposition (Jeremiah 1:7–8, 18–19).

Jeremiah warned the kings and people of Judah to repent to avoid exile. They had broken God's covenant (special agreement), mainly through idol worship (Jeremiah 10:1–16), and faced the consequences (Deuteronomy 27–28). They refused God's call to repent, so Jeremiah later announced that God's judgment was unavoidable.

Judah's leaders especially disliked Jeremiah. King Jehoiakim despised him and tried to stop him from speaking. King Zedekiah secretly asked for Jeremiah's advice but gave in to his officials when they wanted to silence the prophet. However, God's word could not be stopped. The promised judgment occurred in 586 BC: Jerusalem was attacked, the temple was destroyed, and Judah's leaders were either killed or sent to Babylon.

Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, knew about Jeremiah and liked him (Jeremiah 39:11–12). Because of this, the captain of the Babylonian army let Jeremiah stay with the people left in Judah. Jeremiah advised those who stayed to accept Babylon's rule, even after Judean rebels killed Gedaliah, the governor appointed by Babylon. The Judeans ignored Jeremiah's advice and fled to Egypt. Jeremiah was taken with them, and little more is known about him after that. Tradition says he was stoned to death by Jewish exiles in Tahpanhes, Egypt.

Jeremiah was constantly rejected, imprisoned, and physically abuse during his life. But, his ministry did have positive aspects. He predicted that the exile to Babylon would be temporary (Jeremiah 25:1–14) and that God would create a new covenant with his people (31:31–34). Jesus Christ fulfilled this promise (Luke 22:20).

Passages for Further Study

2 Chronicles 35:25; 36:12, 21; Jeremiah 1:1–10; Jeremiah 13:1–14; 18:1–12; 19:1–20:6; 24:1–10; 26:1–29:32; 32:1–15; 36:1–44:30; Daniel 9:2; Matthew 16:14; 27:9

Jeroboam I

Jeroboam I was the son of Nebat from the tribe of Ephraim. He was the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel. He ruled from 931 to 910 BC. He led the northern ten tribes into actions that caused the kingdom's destruction.

Jeroboam started his political career by managing Solomon's labor forces in Ephraim and Manasseh (1 Kings 11:26–28). Since Solomon had turned away from the Lord, God decided to take the ten northern tribes from David's family. The prophet Ahijah told Jeroboam that the Lord chose him to lead those tribes and promised him a lasting dynasty if he remained faithful (1 Kings 11:29–39). Solomon found out and tried to kill Jeroboam, who fled to Egypt for safety (1 Kings 11:40; compare Saul and David, 1 Samuel 18:5–20:42).

When Solomon died, his son Rehoboam became king in Judah. However, the northern tribes needed to confirm his rule separately. Seeing an opportunity, Jeroboam led the northern leaders to Rehoboam to ask for relief from the hard labor Solomon had imposed on them (1 Kings 12:1–4). Rehoboam unwisely rejected their request (1 Kings 12:5–14), leading the north to rebel and choose Jeroboam as their king (12:20). Thus, the kingdom divided, as God had promised.

Jeroboam did not stay loyal to God. He feared that if his people worshiped at the temple in Jerusalem, they would support the southern kingdom. Lacking faith in God to secure his rule, he made his own plan to win his people's spiritual loyalty. He built two gold calf shrines at the north and south of his kingdom (1 Kings 12:26–33). God was unhappy with these shrines and sent a prophet to condemn Jeroboam. Although Jeroboam initially reacted to the prophet's display of divine power, the calf shrines remained throughout the northern kingdom's history from 931 to 722 BC. Jeroboam's false religion was a main reason for the northern kingdom's destruction in 722 BC (1 Kings 14:14–16; 2 Kings 17:5–23).

Because of Jeroboam's sins, God did not grant him a lasting dynasty (1 Kings 13:33–34). Although Jeroboam's son Nadab became king after his father's death, a usurper named Baasha assassinated him and the rest of Jeroboam's descendants two years later (1 Kings 14:20; 15:25–31).

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 11:26–14:20; 15:6–7, 25–28; 2 Chronicles 10:1–13:22

Jeroboam II

Jeroboam II was the son of Jehoash. He ruled as king of Israel for 41 years, from 793 to 753 BC. His time as king was longer than any other northern king. He followed the bad example of Jeroboam I (2 Kings 14:23–24). Jeroboam II was not a relative of Jeroboam I, but they had the same name.

During his time, the northern kingdom reached its largest size and greatest wealth since Solomon. Archaeological evidence from Jeroboam's capital, Samaria, shows the wealth of Israel's royal house during his reign. One reason for Israel's new prosperity was Assyria's decline in power, which allowed the northern kingdom to grow. The prophet Jonah predicted this prosperity as God's promise (2 Kings 14:25). Even after 150 years of turning away from God in the northern kingdom, God showed his faithful love by offering Israel his mercy (2 Kings 14:26–27).

During Jeroboam II's reign, wealth increased, but justice did not. Rich landowners oppressed poorer ones, forcing them to leave their farms for cities. Government corruption, economic depression, and political weakness grew, while Israel's spiritual state worsened. God sent prophets to challenge Israel's leaders and people. Amos and Hosea spoke against the widespread corruption. Amos strongly criticized the rich for oppressing the poor. He warned of Jeroboam's upcoming death and Israel's punishment (Amos 7:10–17).

After Jeroboam II died, the northern kingdom quickly declined. Between 753 and 722 BC, six kings ruled one after another, and most were assassinated. In 722 BC, about 30 years after Jeroboam II's reign ended, Assyria destroyed the northern kingdom and deported its people. This action was seen as a judgment on the sins of Jeroboam II and other northern kings.

Passages for Further Study

2 Kings 13:13; 14:16, 23–29; Hosea 1:1; Amos 1:1; 7:10–17

Jethro (Reuel)

Jethro, also known as Reuel (Exodus 2:16–18; Numbers 10:29), was the priest of Midian (Exodus 2:16). Moses saved Jethro's seven daughters from rough shepherds at a well and helped them water their flocks. At home, they told their father about this surprising encounter with an Egyptian. Jethro was grateful and invited Moses for a meal. Moses decided to settle there. Later, Jethro gave his daughter Zipporah to Moses in marriage.

While Moses lived in Midian with his father-in-law, he met God at the burning bush (Exodus 3:1–2). Before going to Egypt, Moses asked Jethro for permission to leave. Later, he sent his family to stay with Jethro during the exodus from Egypt.

While Moses and the Israelites were in the wilderness, Jethro returned with the family of Moses. Jethro heard about Yahweh saving his people from Egypt and recognized him as greater than all other gods. He worshiped Yahweh with a burnt offering and sacrifices, aligning himself with Israel (Exodus 18:11). In response, Israel's

leaders joined him for a sacrificial meal in God's presence (Exodus 18:12).

Jethro noticed Moses was overwhelmed with managing the many Israelites. He advised Moses on organizing the people better and resolving their disputes (Exodus 18:13–23). Moses followed this advice and chose capable men to help as leaders and judges (Exodus 18:24–27). Jethro returned to Midian and did not interact further with Israel, but his son (Numbers 10:29–33) and other descendants later settled with the Israelites (Judges 1:16; 4:11).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 2:16–25; 3:1; 18:1–27; Numbers 10:29; Judges 1:16; 4:11

The Jewish High Council

The high council of Jewish leaders in Jerusalem had significant power in governing the Jewish people. It is traditionally called the Sanhedrin, a transliteration of the Greek word sunedrion, which means "council."

Jewish tradition says the Sanhedrin began when Moses chose seventy elders (Numbers 11:16). However, the earliest reference is in Josephus's Antiquities 12.3.3, from the time of Antiochus the Great, from 223 to 187 BC. The Sanhedrin likely started as a self-governing group of leaders under Persian rule (see Ezra 5:5–10; Nehemiah 2:16). The priestly class, led by the high priest, controlled the high council. Roman rulers and the Pharisees influenced these priests to different extents. Herod the Great had a strong influence over the Sanhedrin's activities.

The Sanhedrin dealt with the legal and religious matters of Judaism. This included making judicial decisions not settled in smaller courts, known as "local sanhedrins," as well as managing criminal justice and arrests (see Acts 9:1–2). They also made official decisions on Jewish issues, although these decisions were not enforceable. The Sanhedrin could not execute criminals on its own (John 18:31), but it could do so with Roman approval.

The destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 ended the high council's role as the leader of Judaism.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 26:57–68; Mark 14:53–65; 15:1, 43; Luke 22:66–71; 23:50–54; John 11:47–53; Acts 5:21–41; 6:11–8:1; 22:30–23:10; 23:26–30

Jewish Leaders

Jesus often disagreed with Jewish leaders during his public ministry. These leaders believed they were protecting the temple, its sacrifices, the synagogue, and its teachings. During the last week Jesus spent in Jerusalem, these arguments became more intense and helped build the case against him (see Matthew 23).

When John wrote his Gospel, local Jewish synagogues were attacking followers of Jesus in their areas. This conflict influenced John's writing (see Acts 14:19; 1 Thessalonians 2:14; compare Galatians 1:13–14).

The Greek term for "Jewish leaders" could also mean "Jews." However, it specifically referred to the temple leaders who opposed Jesus, judged him, and planned his death on the cross (see John 1:19; 2:18; 5:9–18; 9:18–22). This distinction is important because some view the New Testament, especially John's Gospel, as prejudiced against Jewish people. However, Jesus, who was Jewish, did not oppose all Jews. His opponents were the "Jewish leaders," the religious authorities in first-century Jerusalem.

Passages for Further Study

John 1:19–24; 2:18–20; 5:9–18; 7:1, 10–13, 35–36; 9:13–34; 11:45–54; 12:41–43; 18:28–36; 19:6–8, 12–16, 31, 38; 20:19; Acts 6:10–12; 7:54–58; 12:11; 21:11; 25:1–3, 7; 26:1–11; 28:17–24; 2 Corinthians 11:24

Jezebel

Jezebel, daughter of Ethbaal, king of Sidon (1 Kings 16:31), married King Ahab of Israel, likely to strengthen a political alliance between their nations. Jezebel supported Baal worship and insisted on total control for the king and queen.

Jezebel persuaded Ahab to start Baal worship in Samaria and to set up an Asherah pole (1 Kings 16:30–33). She attempted to eliminate God's prophets (1 Kings 18:4) and supported many of Baal's prophets in the royal palace (1 Kings 18:19).

Elijah confronted Jezebel and Ahab on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:19–40). There, he challenged Israel to follow the true God. After God showed His power, the Israelites recognized Him and assisted Elijah in killing the false prophets. When Jezebel learned of this, she threatened Elijah, causing him to flee (1 Kings 19:1–3).

Later, Jezebel advised her husband on how to take a vineyard from their neighbor Naboth. When Naboth refused to sell it, Jezebel made a plan to falsely accuse him of cursing God and the king. As a result, Naboth was executed. Ahab took the vineyard, but God sent

Elijah to announce judgment on Jezebel and Ahab (1 Kings 21:20–24). Ahab died soon after (1 Kings 22:29–40), but Jezebel lived through her son Ahaziah's reign. She was later executed when Jehu destroyed the ruling family, fulfilling God's judgment against her (2 Kings 9:30–37).

Jezebel's evil influence reached the southern kingdom of Judah when her daughter Athaliah married Jehoram, the son of King Jehoshaphat (see 2 Kings 8:18, 26–27).

Her name has long been linked with evil. In Revelation 2:20, Jezebel is a prophetess who led the Christians of Thyatira to commit sexual sins and eat food offered to idols.

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 16:31–21:28; 2 Kings 9:1–37; Revelation 2:20

Joab

Joab was David's nephew and the son of David's sister Zeruiah (1 Chronicles 2:13–16). His brothers were Abishai and Asahel. Joab became the commander of David's armies due to his bravery and military skill (2 Samuel 2:18; 8:16; 11:1; 1 Chronicles 18:15). He earned the commander's position by being the first to attack the Jebusite city of Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 11:4–9). Joab also stopped a rebellion among the Arameans and Ammonites (2 Samuel 10:1–19; 1 Chronicles 19:8–15). He won many important battles for David against the northern army of Israel, which was under Abner's strong leadership (2 Samuel 2:12–32).

Joab often acted to support what he thought were David's interests. For example, he worked with David in the death of Uriah the Hittite to hide the king's adultery with Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11:1–27). He convinced David to let Absalom return to court (14:1–33). He also tried to stop David from taking a census that made God angry (2 Samuel 24:1–9; 1 Chronicles 21:1–6).

Joab was loyal to David but sometimes acted for himself and ignored the king's orders. When Abner killed Joab's brother Asahel (2 Samuel 2:23), Joab took revenge by killing Abner (2 Samuel 3:26–30), even though Abner had become loyal to David (2 Samuel 3:12–19). Later, Joab killed his cousin Amasa, who had led Absalom's army (2 Samuel 20:8–10; 17:25). This happened after David made Amasa the commander instead of Joab (2 Samuel 19:13; 20:4).

Joab also killed Absalom against David's direct order (2 Samuel 18:5, 10–17). He then criticized David for mourning Absalom's death instead of praising the army (2 Samuel 19:5–7). Joab was ruthless and regained the top position in David's army (2 Samuel 20:23; 24:2; 1 Kings 1:19).

Joab's decision to support Adonijah's claim to the throne led to his death (1 Kings 1:5–7). Near the end of his life, David ordered Solomon to put Joab to death for killing Abner and Amasa. After becoming king, Solomon ordered Benaiah to kill Joab. Joab ran to the altar and grabbed its horns (corners) for protection (1 Kings 2:28–34). Joab faced the same end he had given others, and his executioner became the new commander of Israel's army (1 Kings 2:35).

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 2:13–32; 3:22–39; 8:16; 10:7–14; 11:1–25; 12:26–28; 14:1–33; 17:25; 18:2–19:13; 20:7–23; 24:2–9; 1 Kings 1:7, 19; 2:28–35; 11:15–16; 1 Chronicles 2:16; 11:6–8; 18:15; 19:8–15; 20:1; 21:2–6; 26:28; 27:24, 34; Psalm 60:1–12

John Mark

John Mark, who wrote the first Gospel (the Gospel of Mark), helped three early missionaries:

- Barnabas
- Paul
- Peter

Barnabas and Paul took Mark as an assistant on their first missionary journey. However, Mark left them and returned to Jerusalem before the trip ended (Acts 12:25; 13:4–5, 13). Because of this, when Barnabas wanted to bring Mark on the second trip, Paul refused. This disagreement split the team: Barnabas took Mark, his cousin, while Paul chose Silas. The two pairs then went their separate ways (Acts 15:36–41).

Later, Paul and Mark reconciled, and Mark became his assistant again. In Colossians, Paul calls Mark a coworker and suggests he might soon send him to visit the church in Colossae (Colossians 4:10; see also Philemon 1:24). Even later, when Paul awaited execution in a Roman prison, he asked Timothy to bring Mark because he believed Mark would be helpful in his ministry (2 Timothy 4:11).

Mark likely helped Peter with his missionary work in Italy near the end of Peter's life. In one of Peter's letters, he affectionately calls Mark his "son" who is with him (1 Peter 5:13). Early Christian tradition describes Mark as Peter's "interpreter" and suggests that Mark got his information about the life and words of Jesus directly from Peter (Eusebius, Church History 3.39.16).

Mark's Gospel is generally considered the earliest of all the Gospels. It was almost certainly a primary source for Matthew and Luke when they wrote their

own Gospels. For this reason, Mark's Gospel is one of the most influential early Christian writings.

Mark's story shows that God can fix human mistakes and mend difficult relationships for Christ and the good news. Early failures do not stop someone from having a meaningful and impactful life of service.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 12:12, 25; 13:4–5, 13; 15:36–39; Colossians 4:10; 2 Timothy 4:11; Philemon 1:23–24; 1 Peter 5:13

John, Son of Zebedee

John was one of the twelve closest followers of Jesus. These followers are called apostles. John was the brother of James and the son of Zebedee. Jesus chose these twelve men as his special representatives and gave them authority to teach others about him. Their work helped start the early church. Early tradition says John, Son of Zebedee, wrote the Gospel of John, the Letters of John, and the Book of Revelation.

John and his brother James were among the closest followers of Jesus (Mark 5:37; 9:2; 13:3; 14:33). Their mother, Salome, might have been Mary's sister, who was the mother of Jesus (compare Matthew 27:56; Mark 15:40; 16:1; John 19:25). John's name usually appears after James's, suggesting John was younger. James and John were fishermen like their father (Matthew 4:21; Mark 1:19). They fished with Peter and Andrew, another pair of brothers who became disciples (Luke 5:8–10).

They were among the first disciples Jesus called, and they left everything to follow him (Matthew 4:22; Mark 1:20; Luke 5:11; compare John 1:35–40). Jesus named them "Sons of Thunder" (Mark 3:17). This name might mean they were loud or quick-tempered (see Luke 9:54). At one point, the brothers upset the other disciples by asking for special positions in the future kingdom (Matthew 20:20–28; Mark 10:35–45; compare Luke 22:24–27).

People believe John is the unnamed "disciple Jesus loved" and "another disciple" mentioned in the Gospel of John (John 13:23–25; 18:15–16; 19:26–27; 20:2–10; 21:20–24). He might have been the unnamed disciple of John the Baptist who, along with Andrew, became an early follower of Jesus (John 1:35–40).

John's name appears three times in Acts. Each time, he works with Peter (Acts 3:1–11; 4:1–23; 8:14–25). Paul called him one of the "pillars" of the church in Jerusalem (Galatians 2:9). This meant John was an important leader in the Jerusalem church.

The most common tradition about John's later life is that he moved to Ephesus, where he eventually became the bishop of Asia Minor. He lived to an old age and died peacefully among friends. John's Gospel gives a deep picture of Jesus, and his letters (1 John, 2 John, and 3 John) offer an inspiring view of the Christian life.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 4:21–22; 10:2; 17:1; 20:20–24; 26:37–46; Mark 1:19–20, 29; 3:17; 5:37; 9:2, 38; 10:35–41; 13:3–4; 14:33–42; Luke 5:10; 6:14; 8:51; 9:28, 49, 54; John 13:23–25; 18:15–16; 19:26–27; 20:2–10; 21:2, 7, 20–24; Acts 1:13; 3:1–11; 4:1–22; 5:17–42; 8:14–25; Galatians 2:9

John the Baptist

John the Baptist was a passionate preacher who lived in the desert and called people to repent (to change their lives by stopping their wrongdoing and turning to God). He became known as "the Baptist" (or "the Baptizer") because he baptized (immersed) people in water as a sign that they were turning away from their sins. John acted like Elijah to prepare people for the Messiah's arrival (Malachi 4:4–5; Matthew 11:14; 17:12; Mark 9:13).

John's birth, like the birth of Jesus, was extraordinary. John's parents were very old and unable to have children (Luke 1:5–25). His mother, Elizabeth, was a relative of Mary, the mother of Jesus (Luke 1:36). So, John was related to Jesus. These two miraculous births around the same time marked the start of God's redeeming work.

John was filled with the Holy Spirit from birth and dedicated his life to preparing people for the Lord's arrival (Luke 1:15–17). He began teaching people when he was about thirty years old while living in the desert (Luke 1:80). He wore clothes made of camel's hair with a leather belt, similar to what ancient prophets wore, and ate desert food (locusts and wild honey, see Matthew 3:4; Mark 1:6). John urged everyone to repent and be baptized (Matthew 3:1–2; Mark 1:4; Luke 3:1–3). He even criticized the religious leaders who came to listen to him (Matthew 3:7–10).

John baptized Jesus, though at first he felt unworthy to do so (Matthew 3:13–17). John knew Jesus was greater than him. While John used water, Jesus would "baptize with the Holy Spirit" (John 1:33; Matthew 3:11; Mark 1:7–8; Luke 3:16; compare John 3:23–30). John encouraged his followers to become disciples of Jesus. Many did, including:

- Andrew (John 1:35–40),
- Apollos (Acts 18:24–26), and

- the twelve disciples at Ephesus (Acts 19:1–7).

John criticized Herod Antipas for marrying Herodias, his brother Philip's wife, which was against the law. To satisfy Herodias, Herod imprisoned and then executed John (Matthew 14:3–12; Mark 6:17–29; Luke 3:19–20). John's imprisonment marked the start of the public preaching of Jesus (Matthew 4:12; Mark 1:14).

Shortly before his death, John appeared confused about Jesus. He sent messengers from prison to ask if Jesus was truly the Messiah (God's chosen one). Jesus did not do what most people expected the Messiah to do. Instead of bringing judgment and a visible kingdom, he brought forgiveness, healing, and a spiritual kingdom. To reassure John, Jesus spoke of the miraculous things God was doing through him (Luke 7:18–23).

John stayed true to his mission throughout his life. He consistently preached about repentance and God's judgment, even to those who did not want to listen. Jesus called John one of the greatest servants of God who ever lived (Matthew 11:2–19; Luke 7:18–35). John was the last in a long line of prophets who predicted the coming of God's Kingdom (Luke 16:16). He stood at the start of a new era, announcing its arrival to everyone willing to hear.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 3:1–15; 4:12; 9:14; 11:2–19; 14:1–12; 16:14; 17:10–13; 21:24–27, 31–32; Mark 1:1–9, 14; 2:18; 6:14–29; 8:28; 9:11–13; 11:29–33; Luke 1:13–17, 36, 39–43, 57–66, 76–80; 3:1–21; 5:33; 7:18–35; 9:7–9, 19; 11:1; 16:16; 20:3–8; John 1:6–37; John 3:23–36; 4:1–3; 10:40–42; Acts 1:5; 10:37; 11:16; 18:25–26; 19:1–7

Jonathan

Jonathan was King Saul's oldest son. He was supposed to be the next king after Saul. However, when God rejected Saul and chose David, Jonathan supported David's rise to power (1 Samuel 18:1–4; 19:1–7).

Jonathan was an excellent military leader. He led his father's army to victory over the Philistine garrison at Geba (1 Samuel 13:3–4). In another bold move, Jonathan and his armor bearer attacked a Philistine outpost alone. This caused confusion and chaos among the Philistine army. This allowed the main Israelite army to attack and win (1 Samuel 14:1–23; see also David's tribute to Jonathan, 2 Samuel 1:22).

Saul had unwisely made an oath that no one should eat until they won. Jonathan did not know about the vow and ate some honey. When he learned of Saul's vow, Jonathan criticized it strongly. Saul would have had Jonathan killed after the battle he helped win if the people had not intervened.

When Jonathan and David met, they quickly became friends (1 Samuel 18:1–4). Jonathan showed his deep love for David by giving him his robe, tunic, sword, bow, and belt. This might have meant that Jonathan believed David should be the next ruler. When Saul tried to kill David, Jonathan spoke up for David and helped him escape safely.

Jonathan stayed with his father even after the Lord made it clear that He had left Saul. As a result, Jonathan died with Saul while fighting the Philistines (1 Samuel 31:2; 1 Chronicles 10:2). Jonathan was a virtuous, brave, and selfless man who always spoke and acted with honesty. His love and courage helped David survive King Saul's mad attacks.

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 13:1–14:46; 18:1–4; 20:1–42; 23:16–18; 31:2; 2 Samuel 1:1–27; 4:4

Joseph

Joseph is famous for his dreams and the beautiful coat his father, Jacob, gave him. He is an example of faith, wisdom, and skill in managing. Despite many challenges, Joseph saved Canaan, Egypt, and his family from starvation during seven years of drought.

Joseph was Jacob's eleventh son and the first child of Jacob's favorite wife, Rachel. Joseph's name means "may he add," showing Rachel's wish for God to give her another son (Genesis 30:24). Rachel later died while giving birth to Benjamin, Joseph's only full brother.

Joseph's brothers were jealous of him because of his dreams. They sold him to a passing caravan and made Jacob think an animal had killed him. In Egypt, Joseph quickly became important, but he was jailed when his master's wife falsely accused him. In prison, he correctly interpreted dreams for other inmates and was later called when Pharaoh could not understand his own dreams. Joseph explained Pharaoh's dreams, which were about a coming famine, with insight and wisdom.

Pharaoh released him thirteen years after he had been brought to Egypt as a slave and appointed him to lead the nation in preparing for the famine. When Joseph's brothers came to buy grain in Egypt, they appeared before him but did not recognize him. Later, their regret and Judah's plea led Joseph to reveal his identity. The family reconciled and reunited when Jacob came to live in Egypt.

Jacob blessed Joseph's sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, and adopted them as his own (Genesis 48:5–20). Each became a separate tribe in Israel. Jacob placed Ephraim first and gave him the birthright (Genesis 48:17–20). Ephraim became one of Israel's strongest tribes and led the northern kingdom after it split during Rehoboam's reign (see 1 Kings 11:26–12:33). Several prophets refer to the northern kingdom as Ephraim (for example, Ezekiel 37:15–19; Hosea 5:3–5) and Joseph (for example, Obadiah 1:18).

Joseph believed the Israelites would return to the land God promised them. His dying wish was for his bones to be buried in Canaan when they left Egypt (Genesis 50:24–26; see Exodus 13:19; Joshua 24:32). Joseph's story shows the life of a faithful man with godly character who followed God's plan. His name appears often in Scripture, indicating that later Israelites respected him. The Psalms summarize his story (Psalm 105:16–22), and Stephen mentions him in his speech before his martyrdom (Acts 7:9–14).

Joseph's life shows that God controls history, even when bad things occur (Genesis 50:20). God shows his power through his caring and faithful love for his people. Joseph also demonstrates strong faith in God and personal integrity during tough times.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 30:22–24; 37:2–36; 39:1–45:28; 48:1–22; 49:22–26; 50:1–26; Exodus 13:19; Deuteronomy 33:13–17; Joshua 24:32; Psalm 105:16–22; Acts 7:9–14

Joshua

Joshua was the son of Nun. He was the assistant of Moses and became Israel's leader after him. Joshua led the young nation across the Jordan River into Canaan, the land God promised to Abraham, by faithfully following God's guidance.

Before Israel reached Mount Sinai, Joshua led Israel's warriors when Amalek attacked them (Exodus 17:8–13). Soon after, he was one of the twelve men Moses sent to explore the promised land (Numbers 13:1–16). Despite popular opinion, Joshua and Caleb urged Israel to take Canaan immediately (Numbers 13:22–14:9). As a result, only they, among the twelve spies, entered Canaan (Numbers 14:30, 36–38).

God chose Moses to appoint Joshua as his successor (Numbers 27:15–23; Deuteronomy 34:9). After Moses died, Joshua led the Israelites across the Jordan River (Joshua 1:1–18; 3:1–4:24) to conquer Jericho (6:1–27). When Israel lost at Ai, Joshua sought the Lord's guidance and removed sin from Israel (Joshua 7:1–26). Then, Israel defeated Ai (8:1–29). Following God's instructions to Moses (Deuteronomy 11:29–32; 27:1–28:68), Joshua built an altar on Mount Ebal (Joshua 8:30–32). There he read the blessings and curses of God's special agreement (covenant) with Israel (8:33–35). Joshua led campaigns against two groups of Canaanite kings, one in the south and one in the north (Joshua 10:1–43; 11:1–15). These victories allowed the Israelites to settle in the hill country.

After overseeing the division of land among the tribes of Israel, Joshua received his own share in Ephraim (Joshua 19:49–50). He established the cities of refuge where people could go if they accidentally killed someone (Joshua 20:1–9). Joshua also established cities for the Levites to live in (21:1–45). The Levites were the tribe chosen to serve God in the temple, but they did not receive their own territory like the other tribes of Israel. Instead, they were given these cities spread throughout the land.

Joshua allowed the two and a half tribes that settled east of the Jordan River to return home (Joshua 22:1–9). As he aged, Joshua urged Israel to stay loyal to God (Joshua 23:1–24:28). His farewell speech at Shechem reviewed God's actions with Israel and ended with the well-known challenge, "choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve... As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD" (Joshua 24:15). Joshua died at 110 years old and was buried in Timnath-serah (Joshua 24:29–30; Judges 2:8–9).

Joshua showed great faithfulness throughout his life, except when he dealt with the Gibeonites (Joshua 9:1–27). He did not ask the Lord for guidance on a decision. Israel served God faithfully under Joshua and the elders he trained (Joshua 24:31; Judges 2:7). Stephen mentions Joshua in his sermon before his martyrdom (Acts 7:45). The writer of Hebrews uses Joshua's conquest of Jericho to illustrate faith (Hebrews 11:30). Joshua and Jesus are the same name in the Hebrew language. This connection is meaningful because both men were leaders who helped save people. Joshua helped the people of Israel by leading them into the land of Canaan, where they could live safely, while Jesus leads all who believe in him into eternal salvation.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 17:8–15; Numbers 13:1–14:38; 27:15–23; 34:17; Deuteronomy 34:9; Joshua 1:1–18; 4:1–24:33; Judges 2:6–9; Hebrews 11:30

Josiah

Josiah was king of Judah from 640 to 609 BC. He was a godly man, unlike his grandfather Manasseh and

his father Amon. Josiah followed the Lord with all his heart, soul, and strength. He obeyed all the laws of Moses (2 Kings 23:25).

Manasseh was king from 697 to 642 BC. During this time, the kingdom of Judah was very wicked and worshiped idols. Even though Manasseh repented near the end of his reign, things got worse under his son Amon, who ruled from 642 to 640 BC. Amon was so bad that his own officials killed him. Then, they made Josiah king (2 Kings 21:23–24; 22:1; 2 Chronicles 33:24–34:1). He was eight years old.

When Josiah was sixteen, he started to seek the God of his ancestor David (2 Chronicles 34:3). From then on, he focused on purifying the worship of God's people. At twenty, Josiah began removing pagan worship places, especially the disliked pagan worship center at Bethel. Josiah fulfilled prophecy (1 Kings 13:1–3) by destroying its altar and burning the bones of pagan priests to desecrate the site (2 Kings 23:15–18).

When Josiah was twenty-six, he organized repairs to the temple (2 Kings 22:3–7). During this process, the priest Hilkiah found the Book of the Law and read it to Josiah. Josiah was upset by its warnings against abandoning faith (2 Kings 22:8–20). He then tried harder to follow God's instructions and led the people in worshiping the Lord. He celebrated Passover as the law required, destroyed many objects used in Baal and sun worship, and removed pagan shrines in Judah (2 Kings 23:4–14). The prophets Zephaniah and Jeremiah, who spoke for God during his time, apparently supported Josiah in all this.

On one important occasion, Josiah did not listen to God's guidance, which led to his death (2 Kings 23:29–30; 2 Chronicles 35:20–25). In 609 BC, Pharaoh Neco marched toward Carchemish to help the Assyrian army against Babylon. Josiah delayed Neco at Megiddo, possibly to support the Babylonians. Neco claimed that the Lord wanted him to fight Babylon, but Josiah attacked him and was killed in battle. Jeremiah and the people of Judah mourned Josiah deeply (2 Chronicles 35:25).

Josiah was faithful, but the people were not. After he died, his sons and successors turned away from the Lord. Despite Jeremiah's increased efforts, the people did not repent. The turbulent years after Josiah's death ended with the destruction of Jerusalem and the exile of its citizens to Babylon from 605 to 586 BC.

Passages for Further Study

1 Kings 13:2; 2 Kings 21:24–23:30; 2 Chronicles 33:25–35:27; Jeremiah 1:1–4; 22:13–23; 25:3; 36:2; Zephaniah 1:1

Judah

Judah is most famous for being the ancestor of King David and of Jesus Christ. Judah was not the oldest son and did wrong things as a grown man (Genesis 38). Despite that, God chose Judah to continue the lineage of King David and of the Messiah (see 1 Chronicles 2:1–17; 3:1–24; and Genesis 49:8–12; Matthew 1:1–16; Luke 3:23–34).

Judah was the fourth son of Jacob's twelve sons (Genesis 35:23; 1 Chronicles 2:1). Leah was happy to have her fourth son. She named him Judah, which means "praise" (Genesis 29:35).

Judah had five sons:

1. Er
2. Onan
3. Shelah
4. Perez
5. Zerah

Bathshua, a woman from Canaan, was the mother of Er, Onan, and Shelah (Genesis 38:1–5; 1 Chronicles 2:3). Perez and Zereh were twins. Tamar, Judah's daughter-in-law, was their mother (Genesis 38:27–30; 1 Chronicles 2:4).

God killed Judah's first two sons, Er and Onan, in Canaan because of their disobedience (Genesis 46:12). Judah later moved his family to Egypt with his father and brothers (Exodus 1:1–2).

Judah acted recklessly with Tamar but he took responsibility for Benjamin's safety in Egypt (Genesis 38:6–30). He also interceded with Joseph for his brothers (Genesis 44:14–34). When Jacob gave his dying blessing, he granted Judah a leadership role. Future kings of Israel would come from Judah's descendants (see Genesis 49:10).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 29:35; 37:26–27; 38:1–30; 43:1–10; 44:14–34; 46:28; 49:8–12; Ruth 4:12; 1 Chronicles 2:3–4; 5:2; Psalm 108:8

Judas Iscariot

Judas Iscariot is well-known for betraying Jesus to the authorities (Matthew 10:4; Mark 3:19; Luke 6:16).

The meaning of the name Iscariot is unclear. It might refer to a village named Kerioth. Judas Iscariot is different from Judas, son of James (Luke 6:16; John 14:22).

Among the apostles (the closest followers of Jesus), Judas Iscariot was known as greedy. He carried the money bag and had a reputation for stealing from it

Judas Iscariot

(John 12:4–6). The leading priests later offered him a bribe, which convinced him to betray Jesus (Matthew 26:14–16; Mark 14:10–11; Luke 22:3–6).

Jesus called Judas "a devil" (John 6:70–71). He also predicted his betrayal (Mark 14:18–21). The devil put the idea of betrayal into Judas's mind, and Satan entered him during the betrayal (Luke 22:3–4; John 13:2, 27). Judas led soldiers and officers to the garden of Gethsemane at night. There, he found Jesus with his followers. Judas had planned to identify Jesus to the soldiers by giving him a kiss, which was a normal way to greet someone at that time (Mark 14:43–46). Later, Judas was very sorry for betraying an innocent man. He killed himself by hanging himself (Matthew 27:3–10; Acts 1:18–19).

Jesus understood Judas's betrayal as part of God's plan for redemption. It led to the death of Jesus, the Messiah, as the ultimate sacrifice for sin (Matthew 26:24, 53–54; Mark 14:21; Luke 22:22; John 17:12). Although Judas played a role in God's plan, his tragic end was deserved (Acts 1:24–25). It would have been better for Judas if he had never been born (Matthew 26:24; Mark 14:21). Judas's fate serves as a warning to those who seem to follow Jesus but have not personally committed to him (see Hebrews 6:4–6).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 10:4; 26:14–16, 23–25, 46–50; 27:3–10; Mark 3:19; 14:10–11, 18–21, 43–45; Luke 6:16; 22:3–6, 22, 47–48; John 6:70–71; 12:4–6; 13:2, 18, 21–30; 17:12; 18:2–5; Acts 1:16–26